

AI in Oncology: What's Happening Right Now

Welcome to this edition of our Cancer Research Society breakdown! Today we're exploring two exciting developments in AI and cancer care, one showing how AI is now powering a fully virtual oncology clinic, and another introducing AI agents that can think like pathologists. Both show how artificial intelligence is reshaping the way we detect and treat cancer.

NEW EDITION

STORY 1

A Virtual Cancer Clinic Just Made History

What Happened

Color Health's Virtual Cancer Clinic became the **first virtual oncology practice in the US to earn ASCO Certified status.**

ASCO is the American Society of Clinical Oncology, one of the most respected names in cancer care. Getting their stamp of approval is a really big deal.

Why It Matters

For a long time, top quality cancer care meant living near a major hospital or cancer center. This certification proves that a virtual clinic can meet the same high standards for safety, coordinated care, and patient outcomes as a traditional in person practice. It opens the door for millions of people in underserved areas to access expert cancer care from home.

How Color Health's Virtual Clinic Works

Color Health built a nationwide, oncologist led medical group that supports patients through every stage of the cancer journey.



Screening and Prevention

AI powered tools help patients stay on top of cancer screening guidelines, increasing adherence by 77%.



Multidisciplinary Review

Every cancer case gets ongoing review from a full team of specialists, just like a top in person clinic.



Faster Treatment Start

AI enabled workflows cut the time from abnormal screening result to treatment initiation by 66%.



Nationwide Access

More than 1 million people can access Color Health through their employer or health plan as of 2026.

The Numbers Behind Color Health

77%

Higher Screening Adherence

More patients following through on cancer screening guidelines, catching cancers earlier.

66%

Faster Treatment Start

Reduction in time from abnormal result to starting treatment, thanks to AI workflows.

1M+

People With Access

Individuals covered through employers and health plans nationwide as of 2026.

50

States Covered

Truly nationwide reach, so location is no longer a barrier to expert oncology care.

What Is ASCO Certified?

The ASCO Certified program sets the gold standard for outpatient oncology practices. Here are the seven focus areas every certified practice must meet:

Patient Engagement

Active involvement of patients in their own care decisions.

Access to Care

Availability and responsiveness when patients need help.

Evidence Based Medicine

Treatment decisions backed by the latest clinical research.

Team Based Care

Coordinated support from a full multidisciplinary team.

Quality Improvement

Ongoing assessment and continuous improvement of care delivery.

Treatment Safety

Rigorous standards for antineoplastic (cancer drug) therapy.

Palliative Care

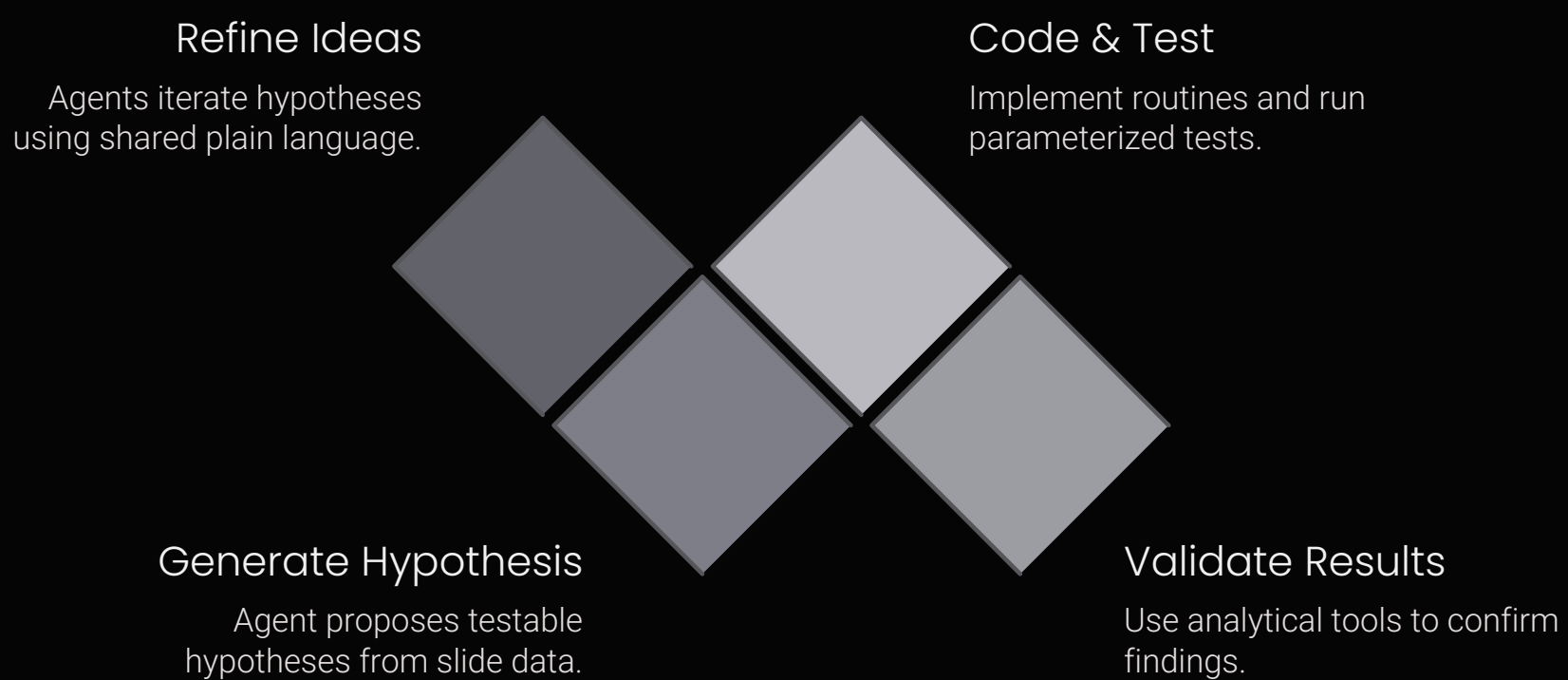
Support for end of life care and goals of care conversations.

STORY 2

Meet SPARK: An AI That Thinks Like a Pathologist

Researchers at the University of Cologne published a study in *Nature Medicine* introducing **SPARK** (System of Pathology Agents for Research and Knowledge), an AI framework that can independently analyze tumor tissue slides, generate biological hypotheses, and validate new cancer biomarkers.

How SPARK Actually Works



SPARK uses a network of interconnected AI agents that communicate using plain language as their shared interface. This means the system can work with complex data from standard H&E (hematoxylin and eosin) stained tissue slides without needing expensive new equipment. Remarkably, it does not require retraining when introduced to new biological concepts, making it highly adaptable as cancer science evolves.

What SPARK Discovered

SPARK was tested on 18 patient cohorts across five cancer types: lung adenocarcinoma, lung squamous cell carcinoma, colorectal cancer, breast cancer, and oropharyngeal squamous cell carcinoma.

Use Case 1: Survival Prediction

SPARK generated **500 unique ideas** compiled into 1,115 verified parameters to predict patient survival from standard tissue slides, some matching known biomarkers.

Use Case 2: Metastasis Detection

The framework generated **118 ideas** to determine whether a tumor had spread, revealing just how complex metastatic behavior really is.

Use Case 3: Breast Cancer Markers

SPARK generated **561 ideas and 2,452 verified parameters** from a breast cancer dataset, many showing independent prognostic value even after adjusting for grade and stage.

AI Deepfakes Are Targeting Doctors, and the AMA Is Fighting Back

The Problem

Physicians are being impersonated by AI generated deepfakes: fake videos, audio clips, and images that make it look like a real doctor is endorsing a dangerous or unproven treatment. These scams erode patient trust and can lead people toward genuinely harmful medical decisions.

The American Medical Association (AMA) called this a "**public health and safety crisis**" and released a formal policy framework to fight back.

The AMA's 7 Principles

- A physician's name, image, and voice are protected interests
- AI content cannot use a doctor's identity without consent
- Consent must be voluntary and revocable at any time
- All AI generated content must be clearly labeled
- There must be a clear process to report and remove deepfakes
- Physicians should not bear the burden of enforcement alone
- AMA will work with lawmakers and regulators to protect patients

Upcoming Webinar: Accelerating Precision Oncology With AI

Wednesday, May 20, 2026 | 8:00 PM - 9:00 PM EDT

This webinar brings together two leading voices in AI enabled cancer care to explore where the field stands today and where it is headed. Topics include matching patients to therapies, designing smarter clinical trials, reducing clinician burnout, and overcoming real world implementation challenges.



Vivek Subbiah, MD

Jeffrey and Christina Bird
Professor of Medicine,
Stanford University School
of Medicine. Associate
Director, Drug Development
and Precision Oncology,
Stanford Cancer Institute.



**Chadi Nabhan, MD,
MBA, FACP**

Chief Medical Officer and
Head of Strategy, Ryght AI,
Inc. Department of Clinical
Pharmacy and Outcomes
Sciences, University of
South Carolina.



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